



LIG1000

**The Language of Business and the Media Across
Cultures**

Final Reflective Essay

Name: Martinas Jucys Brady

Student Number: 22330516

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Introduction

This reflection looks back at my experience with the use of Generative AI tools during the preparation of my vlog. The study that I proposed in my vlog was a modified and modernised version of Hofstede's cultural dimensions framework that addresses two limitations of the initial study. First, I addressed the issue of Hofstede's extremely narrow sampling base, which included IBM employees and then university students at a later date, with a sample that directly reflects the diversity of demographics within the population. This includes ensuring that different age groups, employment statuses and socioeconomic backgrounds are all proportionally represented within the study. Second, I analysed Hofstede's original survey and concluded that the Likert scale and questions used were inefficient in capturing how people actually think and behave in the real world. I replaced his survey with real world and behaviourally grounded questions that ask about everyday situations such as financial behaviour, decision making, future planning and leisure routines.

This was heavily inspired by Fang's (2003) critique of Hofstede's fifth dimension, which identified many weaknesses within the methodologies and philosophical aspects in the way Confucian values had been divided into two contrasting poles, and McSweeney's (2002) analysis of the conceptual and methodological flaws that are present. My group had originally selected Fang's paper for our presentation because we already had prior knowledge and experience with Hofstede's framework, which made these flaws apparent. This existing familiarity with Hofstede's framework also shaped how I used Generative AI during the literature review process.

Planned v. Actual Prompts

My use of Generative AI throughout the literature review was minimal because I already had a deep understanding of the framework before this project began. I used Generative AI to give me an initial revision of his framework as a whole, making sure that I understood everything correctly and clearly, and for the voice used to recite the vlog, to ensure that all information is delivered clearly with no errors (ElevenLabs, 2026). I was concerned that relying on Generative AI too much would hinder my own critical thinking that was essential for the task at hand.

Before starting I planned to use Generative AI in two specific ways; to make sure I didn't miss any other obvious critiques of Hofstede's methodology and to back up my ideas through analysing other examples of cross-cultural research. I ended up using Generative AI a lot less than I intended and expected as the AI lacked the ability to build on my ideas and give me feasible ways to support it. From reading and analysing Fang's (2003) and McSweeney's (2002) paper I was able to clearly see the limitations of Hofstede's framework better. The critique of the Yin Yang principle and how it divided Confucian values was a clearly framed concept and that AI would not be able to come up with on its own.

Whenever I did use Generative AI, I kept the prompts specific and focused. I initially had asked it to recap Hofstede's framework and then also outline the differences between his first four dimensions and then the fifth and sixth dimensions. After initially settling on my own critiques that I would move forward with, I then prompted with "give me the main critiques of Hofstede's cultural dimensions" and the generated text indicated that the main three flaws were "Methodological Flaws", "Static and Reductionist View" and "Conceptual Bias" (PerplexityAI, 2026; see Appendix A.2 for the prompt and full answer).

Feasibility

What worked well was using Generative AI for a straightforward revision and simple fact checking. When I needed a fast summary of basic information, like the basic revision of Hofstede's cultural dimensions, it did a good job. It allowed me to feel more confident before analysing other literature because it refreshed what I already knew. I also was able to use AI to give me insightful reasoning and quick definitions of topics just to give me an even better understanding (PerplexityAI, 2026; see Appendix A.1 and 3 for the prompt and answer).

Deeper analysis and critical thinking didn't work as well and reinforced my initial idea of trying to use it sparingly. When I asked it to critique Hofstede's methods, its answers were shallow and generic (PerplexityAI, 2026; see Appendix A.2 for the prompt and full answer). It kept repeating that the sample used was limited and that people have criticised the cultural assumptions. For example, it couldn't identify the concept that Fang had raised without access to the original source. The AI oversimplified the critiques and could not see the overlap that the critiques it identified presented.

Skills

Throughout this experience it is clear that having strong prior knowledge about a subject is key to working effectively with Generative AI. Thankfully I already had a good understanding of Hofstede's cultural dimensions before the vlog and I could notice straight away when something important was left out or when information was repeated in different ways. Without that prior knowledge I wouldn't be able to identify any of these things and would've been working with misleading information without realising it. This highlights that Generative AI is the most effective in helping people that actually understand the topic rather than those starting from scratch (Harvard Business Review, 2026).

It is also extremely important to know when not to use it. No matter how many prompts I would give about survey issues the AI had not been able to back this up with anything I found myself. I found that there was limited literature available on this specific issue and thus the AI was unable to develop an understanding of what I was talking about without me describing it. It was also unable to build on Fang's critiques and expand them critically. This made me set a boundary of AI usage and having the will power to set AI aside and try to properly dig deep and gain a proper understanding.

Finally, being able to write prompts in a clear and specific way is another important skill. If you give an AI model a vague prompt it will give you back a vague answer, so being clear and concise is essential. When I initially asked it to summarise Hofstede's cultural dimensions, the AI went into the deep philosophical ideas behind each in way too much detail. I had to redo my prompt and make sure that it summarises all six dimensions in an easy to understand and simple format. With more specific prompts I received more specific answers that were tailored to exactly what I wanted. Getting the most out of AI tools requires that you know exactly what you are looking for, which does depend on you having prior knowledge on the questions that you want to ask.

Ethics

The ethical side of using Generative AI in academic work is something I felt strongly about throughout this project. The most important issue for me was honesty. If Generative AI is producing the ideas and arguments in your work and you are presenting them as your own, that is academically dishonest. The fact that it is easy to do does not make it acceptable. In my case, the proposal I made in my vlog, the modified sampling approach, the decision to replace Hofstede's abstract questions with real-world grounded ones and the connection drawn to Fang's critique, all came from my own reading and reasoning. Using Generative AI to produce those conclusions would have made the work dishonest and the tool would not have been capable of reaching them anyway.

There is also an ethical concern that connects directly to the subject of the research itself. One of Fang's (2003) central criticisms of Hofstede is that his fifth dimension reflects a culturally limited and biased perspective, due to being built from a narrow sample and interpreted through a predominantly Western academic framework, which produced a distorted picture of Chinese cultural values. Generative AI carries the same risk at a much larger scale. It is trained predominantly on the English language and Western sources, which means it is likely to underrepresent non-Western scholars and to present culturally specific assumptions as though they were universal (Kim and Baek, 2024). For anyone conducting cross-cultural research, this is a serious concern and one that requires the same critical awareness that Fang applied to Hofstede's work.

Finally, I think there is a concern about what excessive use of Generative AI does to a student's own intellectual development (Dolan, 2025). The understanding I brought to this project came from prior study and genuine engagement with the literature. That kind of knowledge cannot be replicated by a tool that summarises what others have already written. Students who repeatedly outsource their thinking to Generative AI are not just risking their academic integrity, but they are sacrificing the development of the very skills that academic study is designed to build.

Conclusion

My experience with Generative AI during this project confirmed what I had suspected going in, that for a task requiring genuine critical thinking, the AI tools have clear and significant limitations. It was useful for the straightforward parts of the process, such as revising my existing knowledge of Hofstede's framework and checking factual details. But it could not build on my ideas, support my arguments in a meaningful way or engage with the kind of philosophical and methodological reasoning that the vlog demanded. My decision to use it minimally was the right one. Going forward I would treat Generative AI as a starting point and checking tool, not as a substitute for reading, thinking and developing my own position. Using Generative AI within those limits, with honesty about what it is and what it cannot do, has a genuine and practical place in the research process. Used beyond them, it risks producing work that looks credible on the surface but lacks the depth and integrity that real academic work requires.

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Appendix

1

Prompt:

give me a summary of Hofstede's cultural dimensions
simpler and shorter please, just the simple points

Answer:

Hofstede's cultural dimensions are six simple ways to compare cultures:

- **Power distance:** how much people accept hierarchy and unequal power.
- **Individualism vs collectivism:** whether people focus on themselves or the group.
- **Masculinity vs femininity:** whether a culture values competition or cooperation.
- **Uncertainty avoidance:** how much people dislike uncertainty and strict rules.
- **Long-term vs short-term orientation:** whether people focus on future goals or present traditions.
- **Indulgence vs restraint:** whether people freely enjoy life or control desires.

Prompt:

give me the main critiques of Hofstede's cultural dimensions

Answer:

Hofstede's cultural dimensions theory faces several key critiques for its approach to understanding national cultures. These limitations highlight issues in methodology, assumptions, and applicability.

Methodological Flaws

The original research relied on surveys from IBM employees in the 1960s-1970s, creating a narrow, non-representative sample biased toward one multinational corporation and mostly male respondents.

Factor analysis reduced complex data to six dimensions, which critics argue oversimplifies cultural nuances and ignores variability within nations.

Recent studies show only two dimensions (indulgence vs. restraint, long-term vs. short-term orientation) hold up reliably at the individual level.

Static and Reductionist View

The model treats cultures as fixed national traits, failing to account for changes over time, subcultures, or hybrid identities shaped by globalization and migration.

It promotes stereotyping by assigning single scores to entire countries, overlooking regional, generational, or class differences.

Conceptual Biases

Dimensions like masculinity-femininity are seen as Eurocentric and potentially sexist, framing cultures in bipolar, value-laden oppositions.

National culture assumptions ignore ethnic diversity within borders and question causality between dimensions and behaviors.

Prompt:

define the concept of Confucian dynamism in bullet points and easy to understand language

Answer:

Confucian dynamism is a cultural dimension from Geert Hofstede's model, also known as long-term orientation. It measures how societies balance future rewards against short-term gains, rooted in Confucian values like perseverance and thrift.

Core Definition

- Describes a society's focus on long-term thinking versus sticking to quick results or past traditions.
- High scores mean planning for the future, adapting, and saving; low scores prioritize immediate gains, respect for tradition, and spending now.

Key Traits

- **High Confucian dynamism** (e.g., China, Japan): Emphasizes persistence, thriftiness, education for future success, and flexibility in rules.
- **Low Confucian dynamism** (e.g., USA, some European nations): Values quick social obligations, tradition, personal stability, and enjoying today.
- Originated from Michael Bond's Chinese Value Survey to explain East Asian work ethics beyond Hofstede's original four dimensions.

Practical Impact

- Influences business: Long-term oriented cultures invest patiently; short-term ones seek fast profits.
- Not a religion but practical life rules from Confucius (500 BCE), stressing hierarchy, effort, and harmony over time.